Ludwig van Beethoven

Piano Sonata No. 14 in C♯ Minor

Op. 27 No. 2

“Moonlight Sonata”

1st Movement

composed 1801 • published 1802

Reddit Urtext Edition

– 2026 –

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„Immer spricht man von der Cis-Moll-Sonate; ich habe doch wahrhaftig Besseres geschrieben. Da ist die Fis-Dur-Sonate etwas anderes!“

𝄢

“Everybody’s always talking about the C-sharp minor sonata; surely I have written better things. There’s the sonata in F-sharp major—that’s something very different!”

Ludwig van Beethoven to his pupil Carl Czerny;
referring to Piano Sonata “à Thérèse” No. 24, Op. 78;
as recounted by Czerny to Otto Jahn in Vienna, 1852.
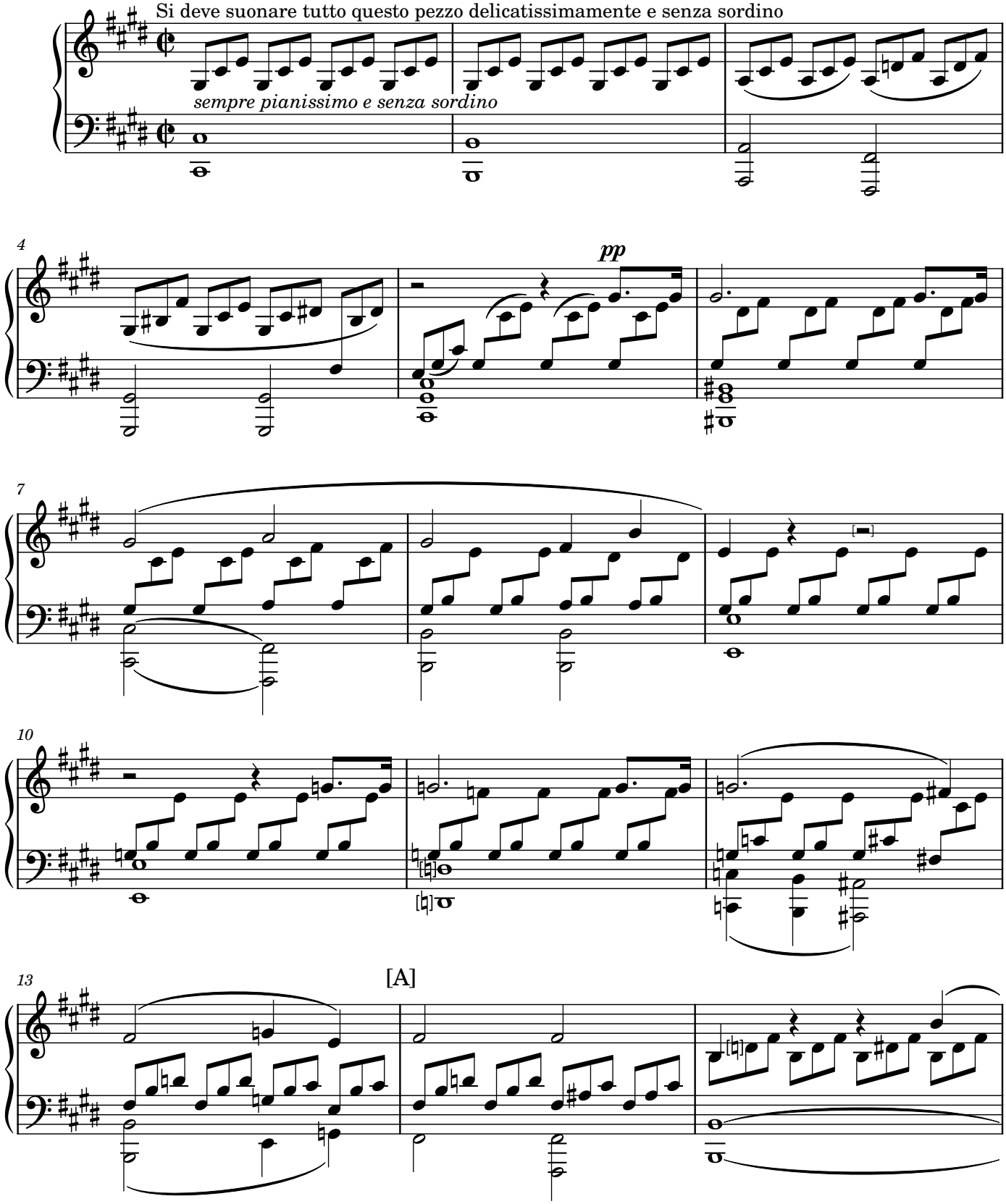
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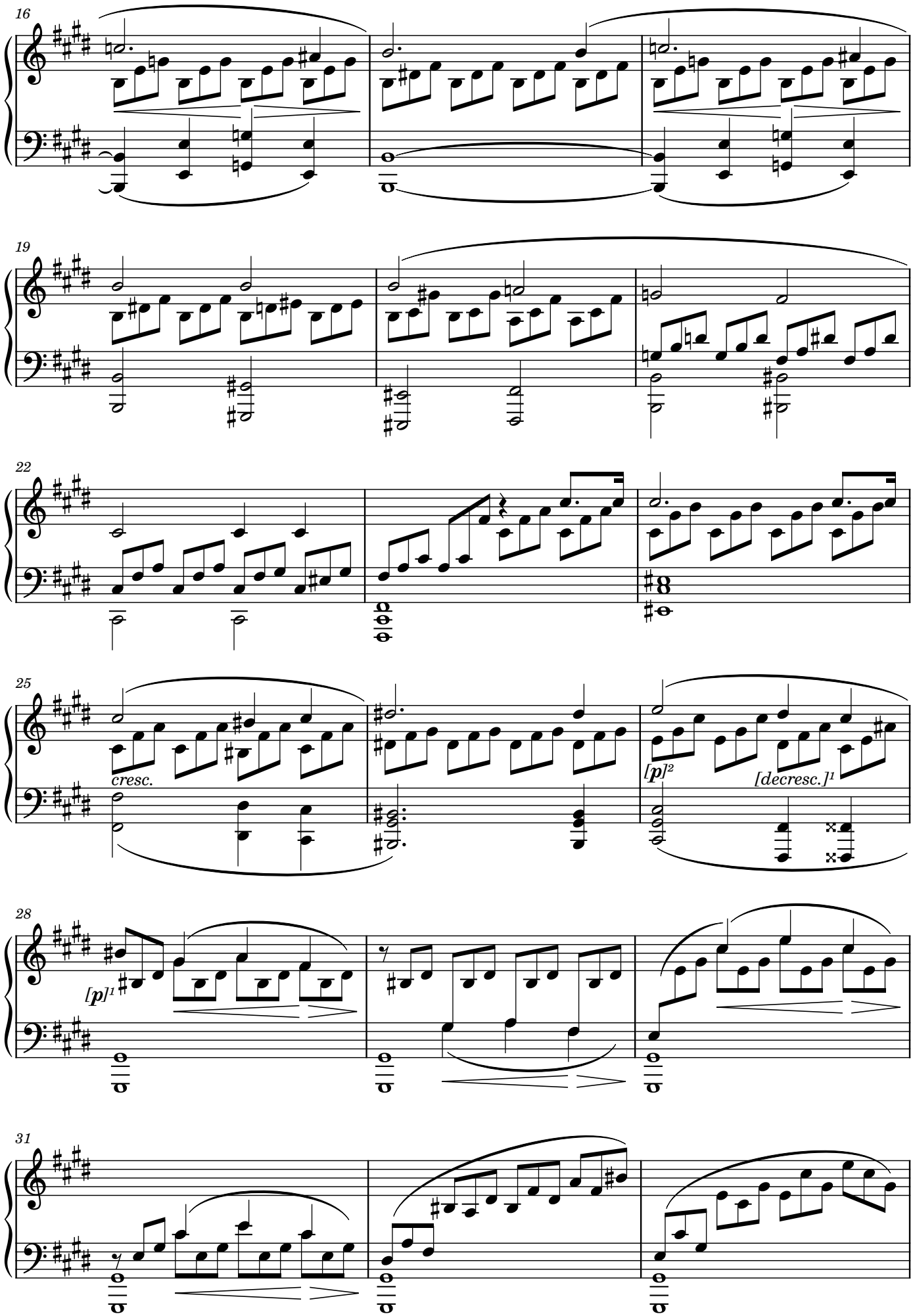
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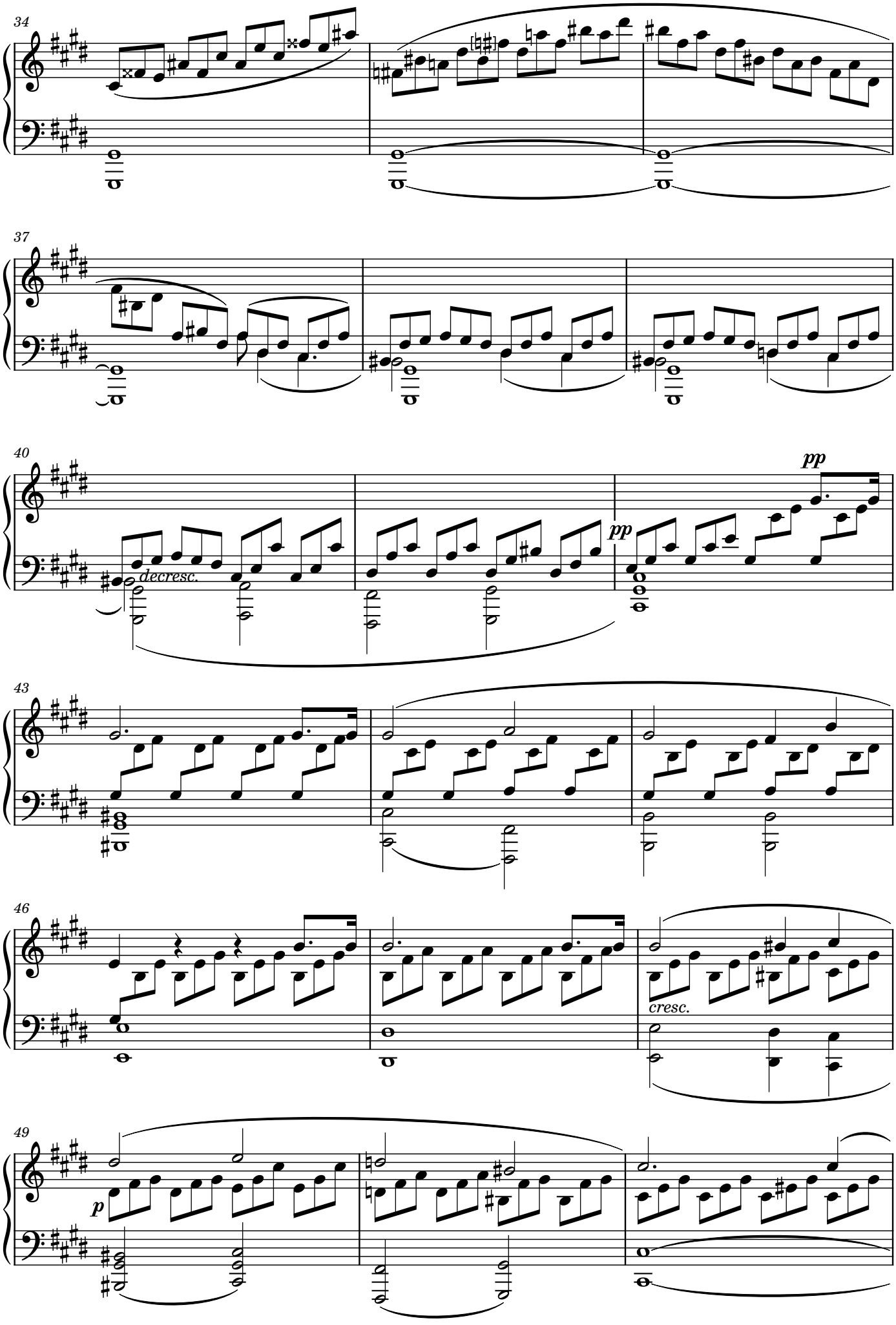
alla Damigella Contessa Giulietta Guicciardi
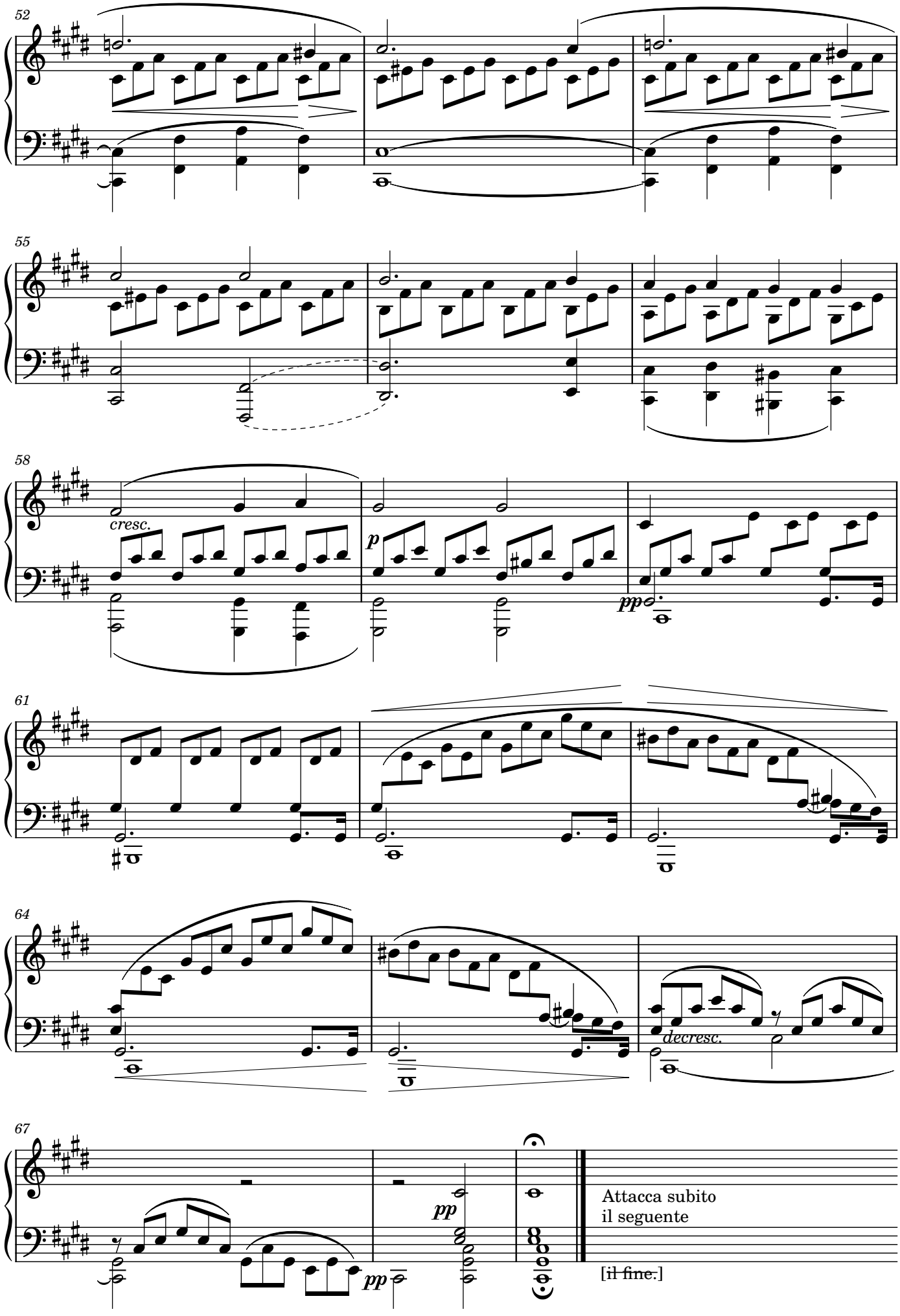
Adagio sostenuto

Si deve suonare tutto questo pezzo delicatissimamente e senza sordino




16
19
22
25
cresc.
[p]²
[decresc.]¹
28
[p]¹
31


34
37
40
decresc.
pp
pp
43
46
cresc.
49
p


52
55
58
cresc.
p
pp
61
64
decresc.
67
pp
pp
Attacca subito
il seguente
[il fine.]

Notes

Source material for this edition is the autograph[1] (henceforth "A") and the original 1802 Cappi edition[2] ("C"). Beethoven was involved in the editorial process of C. One can generally assume that differences to A are intentional alterations from the author's hand. There are also evident signs of plate corrections in C, many if not most of which probably at the behest of the author. Even so, inadvertent errors and inaccuracies cannot be ruled out. Therefore, this edition always considers the sources in conjunction. The 2013 Henle urtext edition[3] ("H") is referenced when the interpretation of A and C is not straightforward, and any editorial decisions are documented below.

The cover page of A is lost, so this edition has to rely solely on C for m1-m13 (read: *measures 1 through 13*). "[A]" marks where this edition begins to rely on the extant A. Beethoven wrote two drafts of m27-m37. The 4th page of A ("A″") comprises the revised version of a first attempt ("A′"). A″ is taken to be authoritative, but A′ is also considered in order to illuminate the author's intent where it is uncertain.

The engraving is based on the style of C, with concessions to modern notation conventions for readability: augmentation dots are not placed at their metric positions, ties connect note to note, spelling of *cresc.* and *decresc.* is normalized. Conspicuous separation of voices is prioritized over vertical alignment, as done in C. Staff distribution, stem direction, and beaming are reproduced faithfully to A and C.

Instructions

C capitalizes every initial s, including in the final "Attacca Subito il Seguente", which A shows with both s's in lowercase. (Also every instance of "Senza Sord(ino)"/"con Sord(ino)" in the 3rd movement: lowercase in A.) This edition concludes the C editor misread Beethoven's long s for a capital letter and puts the instructions in lowercase. C erroneously uses q for g in "Seguente".

C shows prominent spacing around "e" after "delicatissimamente". This might be intentionally separating and thus emphasizing "Senza Sordino", or indicating that "Si deve Suonare tutto questo pezzo" applies only to "delicatissimamente" and not to "Senza Sordino".[4] It could also be a mere artefact of punching the lettering by hand. This edition equalizes all spaces in text.

The dynamic instruction is given in italics as per modern conventions. C does not, though the first s of "pianissimo" appears to be a long or italic s. This seems to be accidental; this glyph is not used anywhere else in C. "Semper" in C is corrected to "*sempre*".

A exhibits a conclusive "il fine." in the ink of the notation, which is crossed out and above which the published instruction "Attacca subito il seguente" is put in different ink, suggesting this was done at a later date. This may indicate that the 1st movement had been initially conceptualized as a standalone piece.[4][5] This edition includes the crossed out instruction in brackets as a curio.

Dynamics

The alignment of < > in this edition reproduces the author's intent as closely as possible insofar as it can be deduced from A. H's interpretation differs from this edition in m52, where it puts the climax of the swell at the 9th ♪ instead of the 4th half-beat. A and C have < > intersect staff lines, slurs, stems, beams, accidentals in various places as space demands. This is avoided in this edition for legibility, while the vertical position above, between, or below the staves is not altered (but see m62/63 below).

m5, m42: A and C place the ***pp*** markings of the RH (*right hand*) melody voice in the treble staff, right before

References

[1] Beethoven House, Bonn, index BH 60. Scan retrievable at International Music Score Library Project: https://imslp.org/wiki/Special:ReverseLookup/51037
[2] Ludwig van Beethoven: *Sonata quasi una Fantasia, Op. 27 No. 2.* Gio. Cappi e Comp., Vienna 1802. Scan retrievable at International Music Score Library Project: https://imslp.org/wiki/Special:ReverseLookup/15808
[3] L. v. Beethoven; M. Perahia (editor, fingering); N. Gertsch (editor): *Klaviersonate Nr. 14 cis-moll Opus 27 Nr. 2 (Mondschein).* G. Henle Verlag, Munich 2013. ISMN 979-0-2018-1062-1, HN 1062.
[4] G. B. Carter: *An analysis of Beethoven's 'senza sordino' marking in the first movement of his Piano Sonata in C sharp minor op. 27 no. 2, including the views of his pupils Carl Czerny and Anton Schindler.* Wensleydale Press, Sydney 2009. ISBN 978-0-9807452-1-4.
[5] L. v. Beethoven; B. Bloch (editor, fingering); P. Hauschild, J. Reutter (editors): *Klaviersonate op. 27/2 Mondscheinsonate.* Wiener Urtext Edition, Vienna 2019. ISMN 979-0-50057-416-3, UT 50433.

the stems of G♯$_4$. This edition reproduces the markings above the staff for legibility since this does not impede comprehension of the intended meaning.

m25: Treble and bass staves are not vertically aligned in A. This edition infers that Beethoven aligns “cres:” with the notes in the bass staff (as “Cres.” also appears in C) and puts *cresc.* at the 1st beat. If it were to be understood as aligned with the notes in the treble staff, the position of *cresc.* would be between the 2nd and 3rd half-beats in A. H puts it at the 2nd beat. Also cf. analogous m48, m58, where there’s no doubt about the intended position of *cresc.*

m27/28: A″ shows no dynamic markings besides <>. C provides the dynamics indicated by brackets and superscript 1 in this edition. This is how most editions put it and how it’s usually performed. Nevertheless, in the absence of dynamic markings in A″, this edition also includes the ***p*** marking in m27 of A′, indicated by brackets and superscript 2. “Decres.” in C is aligned with the 6th ♪, as this edition shows it. It may be intended to apply at the 2nd beat instead, where H puts it.

m40, m66: A and C place *decresc.* (“decres:”/“dcre:” and “Decres.” respectively) in the bass staff in these cases where three voices share the staff and the treble staff remains empty. This edition reproduces this accurately since the author’s apparent intent is to ensure that they’re not misunderstood as only applying to the upper voice(s).

m60: The ***pp*** marking in A appears aligned with G♯$_2$ in the LH (*left hand*) up voice, even though ever so slightly too low to say with certainty. C and H place it below the bass staff. This edition follows Chapman’s argument[6] for the author’s intent in this instance and aligns ***pp*** with the LH up voice. (See also Stem Direction below in further support.)

m62/63: C places the <> between the staves, A above the treble staff. There’s also the faint remnant of a carefully erased < between the staves in m62 of A, leaving little doubt that the placement between the staves is in error, and that the swell should be understood to apply only to the RH; as conversely in m64/65 only to the LH. Therefore, this edition follows A.

Accidentals and Pitch

A often abbreviates consecutive triplet groups when they are identical. C occasionally repeats the accidentals on these groups (m14, m19, m20). Those are not included in this edition. Beethoven sometimes neglects to notate necessary accidentals after the barline (also m11?). C corrects this for m21. Accidentals not found in either A or C (but in H) and that should be present without doubt are given in brackets (m11, m15).

This edition includes all evidently intentional courtesy accidentals even when this is overly cautious under modern conventions: m4 (but see below), m12, m17, m19, m20, m26, m35 (but see below). C does not include the courtesy ♯ on D♯$_5$ in m26 as it directly follows the key signature there.

m4: The redundant ♯s on the 11th, 12th ♪s in C are omitted by this edition.

m20: A and C have a D♯$_1$ (with accidental) in the LH. This is widely accepted to be in error for E♯$_1$, as H and this edition put it. A, C, H, and this edition agree on pitch in every other case.

m35: C includes a courtesy ♮♯ that is not found in A. It appears to be a late correction to the engraved plate, set across the barline as remaining space necessitated, suggesting Beethoven insisted on its inclusion. This edition reproduces it after the barline and, in analogy to other courtesy accidentals, inserts it on the octave in brackets. A/C have a ♯ on D♯$_5$ but not on D♯$_6$. This edition omits it as D♯ already lacks courtesy ♯s in m27-m32.

Stem Direction

It’s apparent that Beethoven instructed C to copy stem direction from A accurately: A and C are identical except in the LH in m54 (A up, C down). Thus it can be surmised that stem direction is quite intentional and in any case conforms to common practices of the time.

References

[6] Chapman 2015: *Grief, Denial and Rage: A Revisionist View of Beethoven’s “Moonlight” Sonata.* Proceedings of the 12th Australasian Piano Pedagogy Conference, Melbourne.

When there's only one voice in the LH (m1-m59), it is up or down stemmed (per measure) as best suits the available space. No meaning is conveyed by this. This edition therefore follows C for m54 as it is better suited for print and mirrors the analogous m52.

The triplet accompaniment voice is generally stemmed such as space allows, with attention given to stemming neighboring similar groups the same. When this voice serves as the main melodic voice in the RH, in m32-m37 1st beat and from m61 on, Beethoven uses stem direction (in the treble staff) to indicate phrases.

In m60, the dotted rhythm fragment of the first subject (m5-m9) reappears as the up voice in the LH. Stem direction is carefully maintained in A and C, even though this necessitates incredibly short stems in m63/m65 4th half-beats. The beams in A even cross in m65; C employs curved beams. Only in m66 is $G\sharp_2$ down stemmed, resulting in two down voices in the bass staff. The upper down voice in m66 is to be understood as distinct from the up voice in m60-m65 which has concluded: ***pp*** no longer applies.

Rests

m9, m23: There are no half rests in C or A. H inserts rests in parentheses. In the absence of A for m9, C has to be taken as it appears. Nevertheless, this edition follows H and includes a rest in brackets. This edition does however not insert a rest in m23 as it may be the author's intent for the RH melody and accompaniment voices to be understood as merging in the 1st beat of m23. Peculiar beaming of the 2nd triplet group might suggest as much; cf. the corresponding groups in m5, m42, m60. The "missing" cadence in the RH has long troubled editors such as Liszt (1857),[7] who first added a ♩ stem to the 1st ♪ of m23, which has become a common practice since.[8]

Slurs

Assessing the author's actual intent is difficult. The slurs in A were often not drawn with great care, even compared to the 2nd and 3rd movements. It can be speculated that this is because Beethoven placed more importance on comprehensive indication in the much faster tempi, and because legato vs. non-legato execution is trivial given the "senza sordino" instruction (according to Czerny, the whole piece "must be played *legatissimo*"[9]). Nevertheless, this edition strives to reproduce the intended slurring as accurately as possible.

C interprets the slurs in A rather poorly in places. From comparing C to A, it can be surmised that the slurs in m1-m13 are not an accurate representation of A, especially in m12, m13. However, any attempt at interpretation runs the risk of deviating even further from the author's intent than C already likely does. Thus, this edition reproduces the slurs in m1-m13 as found in C. But the principal source for the slurs from m14 on is always A.

Beethoven sometimes draws slurs in a "parenthesis" style, enveloping notes rather than beginning and ending the slur on specific ones. This edition normalizes such slurs as no meaning is conveyed by this. He rarely extends slurs over barlines, often drawing them to the end of a measure. This style is reproduced in this edition as Beethoven predates modern phrasing conventions. He treats slurs before and over system breaks inconsistently. This edition has to rely on inference, analogy, and C in cases where his intent is intransparent. H's interpretation is referenced when the intended slurring is doubtful. Uncertainties are as follows.

m25: The lower slur in A extends to the chord in m26. The upper slur terminates at the end of the measure. However, it seems to curve down early since $F\sharp_1$ in m23 above is in the way; the slur even touches the note. It might be in the author's actual intent for the upper slur to extend to $D\sharp_4$ in m26, mirroring the lower slur. On the other hand, the analogous slurs in m48, m58 terminate at the end of their measures, suggesting the extended lower slur might be the unintentional anomaly. C does not extend the lower slur but places it above the bass staff where it crosses through "Cres.", suggesting the inclusion of one or the other is a subsequent correction. Beethoven's intent being this opaque, this edition refrains from interpretation and reproduces the slurs as they appear in A, as H does.

m27: The lower slur in A″ appears in a parenthesis style around the ♩ octaves in the 2nd beat. C and H have it

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References

[7] L. v. Beethoven; Franz Liszt (editor): *Sonaten für das Pianoforte Solo von Ludwig van Beethoven.* Ludwig Holle, Wolfenbüttel 1857.
[8] King Yue Li 2020: *Nineteenth-century Performance and Editorial Practice: A Study of Beethoven's Sonata in C-sharp minor, Op. 27 No. 2.* Arizona State University.
[9] Carl Czerny: *On the Proper Performance of All Beethoven's Works for the Piano.* R. Cocks & Co., London 1846.

from one to the other. However, the placement of the slur over m30 in the next system of A″ leaves too little space to have begun the slur under m27 on the 1st beat as in the analogous m25, m48, m58. The slurs in m27 are in a thinner pen than the slur over m30, suggesting they were done at different times and not necessarily in consecutive order. The lower slur of m27 in A′, having sufficient space there, does indeed begin on the 1st beat. A″ and A′ are otherwise identical in m27-m31 (excluding dynamics; see there). Therefore, this edition follows A′ for the slurs in m27.

m30: C has a slur over the 1st triplet group to the ♩ up stem on the 2nd half-beat that is not present in either version of m30 in A. This edition includes it as found in C since it seems unlikely to be an interpolation not sanctioned by the author. This is however uncertain as m28, m29, m31 lack corresponding slurs. Though this might be explained by their 1st half-beats not being strictly analogous to m30. H omits the slur.

m35/36: The slur over m35 as initially drawn in A″ terminates at the end of the measure. However, Beethoven corrected this at a later time by drawing a straighter end to the slur in thicker ink, extending it slightly over the barline but not quite connecting it to the slur of m36. C has a system break at this position and does not indicate the slurs to be connected. H indicates this particularity by ending the slur of m35 and starting the slur of m36 both on the 1st ♪ of m36. A′ lacks slurs in m32-m36 altogether. This edition infers that the intent of the alteration in A″ is for the slurs to be connected, as stem direction also suggests a continuous phrase, and shows it as such.

m37: A″ and C end the slur over the 1st beat on the 6th ♪. A″ appears to begin the slur under the RH down voice in the 2nd beat on the down stem ♪ and to end it slightly after the 2nd (the augmented) ♩. However, as mentioned, Beethoven often draws slurs in a parenthesis style, making it unclear where a slur is intended to begin or end exactly. A″ also has a system (and page) break after m37, which Beethoven treats inconsistently. C does not include this lower slur. H's interpretation shifts these slurs one ♪ to the right (that is, their end and start respectively) and terminates the second on the 2nd ♩.

This edition ends the slur over the 1st beat as it appears in A″ and C, on the last ♪ of the 1st beat. For the start of the lower slur, H's interpretation is followed. For its end, this edition extends it to the end of the measure. While it seems to terminate in A″ as H puts it (albeit in a parenthesis style), this has to be viewed in the context of the page break. Taken into consideration is also the crossed out m37 of A′, with the corresponding lower slur indeed drawn to the end of the measure in the absence of a page (or system) break. Although this measure differs from m37 in A″ in a number of ways (cf. Appendix).

The slur over the RH up voice in the 2nd beat is drawn in a different pen in A″, suggesting it was done at a different time. It is unclear whether the presence of both slurs (on the up and down voices) is in the author's intent or the one is supposed to be superseding the other, and in that case which one which. The absence of the lower slur in C might suggest the latter. A′ lacks the upper slur. This edition reproduces the slur as found in A″ and C, as H does.

m39: The slur under m39, in contrast to the analogous slurs in m37/38, crosses into m40 in A. The only one of these measures not before a system break in A is m39 (except m37 in A′). In m40, there's a ♩ down stem on the first ♪ that is crossed out and replaced by the present down stem 𝅗𝅥. The slur does not cross the barline in C. It is therefore quite uncertain whether this slur crosses the barline because of inconsistent drawing, a previously intended difference that was not corrected in A (but in C), or an actually intended difference in the final instance (that C failed to include). Given this uncertainty, this edition refrains from interpretation, follows H, and reproduces the slur as found in A.

m55/56 (m7): A exhibits many crossed out notes in m56. The slurs appear in Beethoven's style of ties. It is unclear whether they're in the author's intent or a leftover of a previously intended tied octave. C, following Beethoven's different styles for ties and slurs, also gives them in the form of ties. H puts them as slurs without further comment. They're indicated by dashed lines in this edition. Something similar might be the case in m7. It is impossible to say in the absence of A. Although m7 is otherwise identical to m44, which shows a single lower slur in A and C. H omits the upper LH slur of m7 in analogy to m44, but this edition reproduces the slurs as found in C and refrains from indicating this uncertainty beyond this comment.

m62-m65: A has a system break at m62/63 and slurs over each measure. That the slurs are connected over the break is not apparent from A. C does not have a slur over m62 and shows a continuous slur over m64/65, both contrary to A. H follows C but adds the missing (discrete) slur over m62 and ends the slur over m63 at the up stemmed ♩, as it appears to in A.

Even though C does not accurately reproduce the slurs in A, this is mostly limited to imprecision of their start

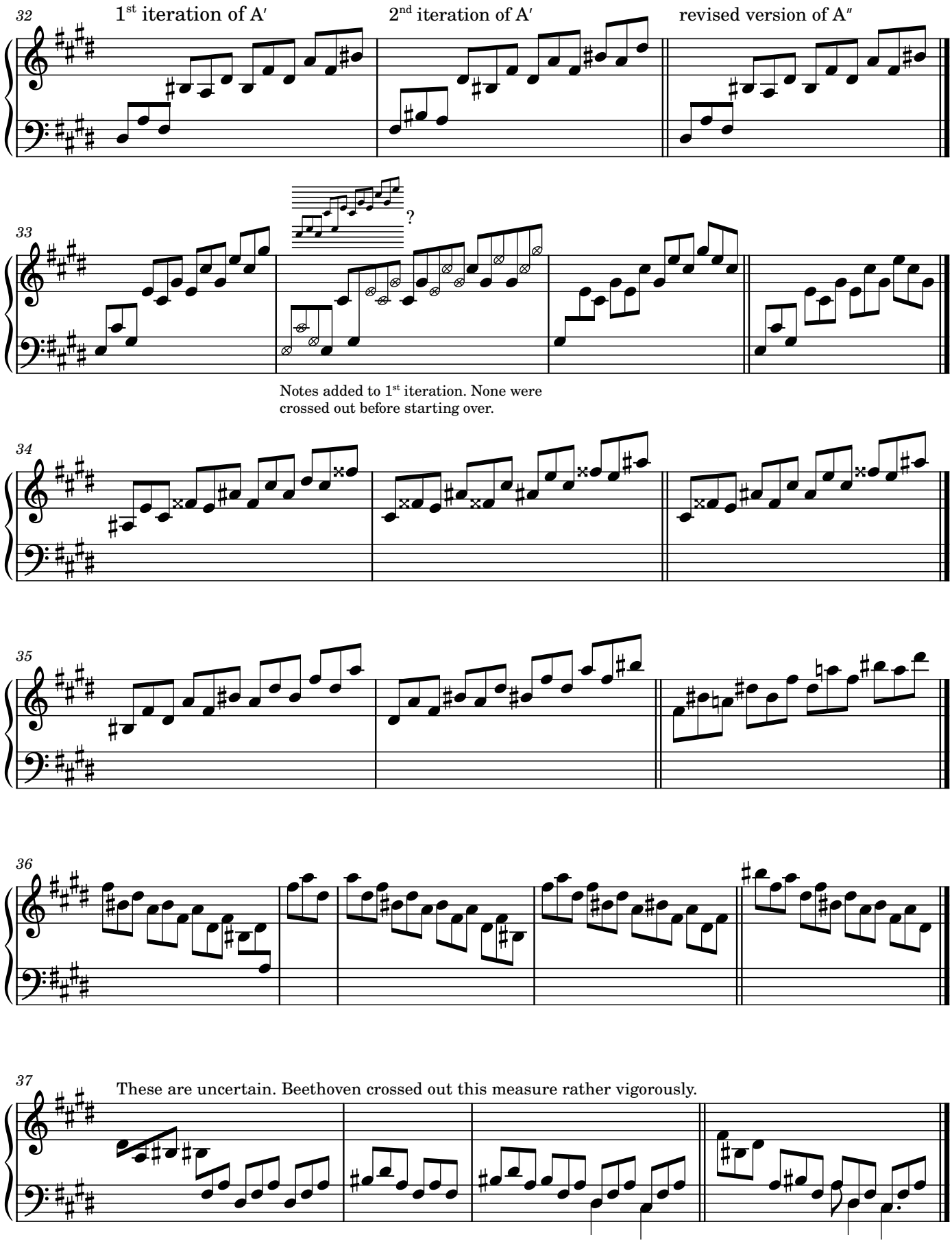
and end points, and the occasional, presumably negligent, omission (m37, m48, m62). At no other place does C connect slurs that are discrete in A, including the 2nd and 3rd movements. Thus it must be speculated that the continuous slur over m64/65 in C is a result of Beethoven having given instructions to the C editor to connect the slurs, but also that he might have been vague and actually meant the slurs over m62/63, them being over a break in A.

Therefore, and on the basis of stem direction, the presence (and respectively absence) of the swell, and in analogy to m32-m37, this edition infers a continuous phrase in m62/63 and connects the slurs, and keeps the slurs over m64/65 discrete, as they clearly are in A. The slur over m62/63 ends on the last ♪ of m63, as it appears in C and in analogy to m65 despite its appearance in A.

m66/67: The slurs in A seem to be drawn hastily, each one being markedly offset to the right; the slur over the 1st beat of m66 so far that it appears to begin on the 2nd ♪, as H puts it. This edition does not consider this to be intentional and begins the slur on the 1st ♪, as C puts it. Instead of the tie in the lowest voice, C shows a slur from m66's $C\sharp_3$ to m67. This is widely regarded to be a misinterpretation of the ambiguously drawn tie in A, as H and this edition put it.

Appendix: Beethoven's Drafts

Each iteration singled out, slurs and left hand omitted for clarity.



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